

EXT. APARTMENT COMPLEX IN ECHO PARK- DAWN

IMANI, 40, serious faced, an undetectably biracial Katherine Hepburn if Katherine Hepburn had thought about but couldn't afford art school. And was biracial. We'll get back to this.

She stands outside her old hatchback in front of a run down apartment complex in Echo Park, Los Angeles. Her mind weighted and her eyes bloodshot.

SUPER -Echo Park -Spring 2017

She calls out over her shoulder towards her car.

IMANI

Be right back.

Ascending the stairs, she drinks in the old beloved mess. The shriveling plants, the broken garden gnome, the off color semblance of care with hints of agricultural incompetence...

She opens the mailbox, reaches inside blindly, and finds... Mail. Shit. Just then a haggard bleary eyed man comes from the back of the house.

ROBERT

Hey, sorry, thanks for dropping off another set of keys. I'm the worst. I lose everything...

IMANI

It's ok. Thats my only spare set tho so...

ROBERT

No, totally, yeah... I'll make a set from these.

IMANI

You know I forgot to have anyone grab my mail for me while I'm gone. I'm sorry... can you do that?

Robert rubs at his eyes.

ROBERT

Yeah, I can hang onto it. You can get that forwarded through the post office too... where you headed?

IMANI
I don't know. Camping...still
deciding where...

Imani covers unsteadily while Robert picks up something is
askew.

IMANI (CONT'D)
(snaps back to herself)

No, it's ok, I'll...

Imani is beat. Robert looks confused.

IMANI (CONT'D)
Good to meet you, take care of the
apartment. Let me know if anything
is confusing.

ROBERT
Yeah, ok.

Robert shuffles back to the back house. Imani glances after
him. With one last forlorn look around the property, she
gathers her will and heads back down the stairs.

Tearing the top off the packages, she peels open and rubs a
decal sticker onto the back window- we don't see it. In the
car she sets the other packages contents on the seat beside
her and exhales. She puts her right arm around into the
backseat and with the left, adjusts the rear view.

We see a DOG (mixed breed, scruffy, bearded) in the rearview.
She reaches for his face, holding his chin. Reassured, he
flops down and settles in. She rights herself forward, both
hands on the wheel, she consults her own reflection in the
rear view...

IMANI
Ok.

BLACK

SUPER TITLE: HOMEWARD

OPENING CREDITS

Road trip type montage, up and down California, Swale theme
music. "If you get lost..."

EPISODE TITLE: The Breadwinner

SUPER- TWO WEEKS EARLIER

EXT. SPRAWLING TECH CAMPUS EL SEGUNDO

Est. shot of a sunny campus 'Welcome!' sign. A mix of palm and oak trees dapple sunlight on TECH EMPLOYEES sitting on benches, laptops open. A couple of Bird scooters fly by. A fellow with bulky headphones in a slow trot carrying a backpack. The stuff of tech campus life.

INT. OPEN OFFICE COMMUNAL LAYOUT

IMANI, looking fresh and hopeful, stylishly dressed (everything thrifted or handmade), looks from left to right-taking it all in.

A newly painted open office layout. WORKERS with more headphones (is this a uniform requirement?) walking to and fro, many looking at their phones. Vast open space filled with young 20 somethings...mostly white and asian men.

A corn-hole setup, a ping pong table- various arrays of office entertainment. Two YOUNG WHITE MEN with the same haircut play ping pong opposite each other. At a beer keg and coffee bar, YOUNG MAN 1 is mixing both spigots into an expensive looking thermos.

YOUNG MAN 2
Office speedball?

YOUNG MAN 1
Five o'clock somewhere!

Cackles of laughter from other men as Imani looks around. Does anyone work around here? She takes a seat against a wall. A young female ASSISTANT approaches as JACK follows her. She looks past Imani.

ASSISTANT
(to Jack)
We're waiting for one more. A woman
named Imani.

IMANI
That's me. Im Imani.

ASSISTANT
(surprised)
Oh...ok. Well, Jack, Imani. Have a
seat here and please, help
yourself to the cold brew!!

IMANI
Thanks. Can't really handle
caffeine...

Jack eyes Imani. Imani attempts a polite smile.

JACK
Im Jack.

Jack is sizing Imani up, somewhere between flirting and
assessing the competition.

IMANI
Imani.

He gets right to it. Pops a mint in his mouth.

JACK
Cool. You here for the lead
research position?

IMANI
Uhhh...yeah, no. I don't think so.
I have a couple years *adjacent*
experience, so I'm open to either
role advertised... depending on
what they're looking for. But
probably the junior... You?

JACK
I'm here for the lead.

Crunches the mint with his teeth.

IMANI
Nice. (Awkward beat. Imani isn't
good at small talk but tries) Where
were you before this?

JACK
Stanford.

IMANI
Teaching? (thinks) What year,
student-wise, did you teach?

JACK
Not teaching, no.

IMANI
...you just graduated?

JACK
Yeah.

Jack sips his coffee, beer or coffee-beer.

IMANI
And you're applying for the lead?

Imani wears the surprise openly. She's weirdly direct. Jack is unfazed.

JACK
I have friends here. Have I seen
you around? Did you go to the D
school?

IMANI
No, I don't. Didn't. Go to
Stanford. I bet that would've been
amazing though. You're lucky. I did
a tech bootcamp -Experience Academy-
last year. I worked in market
research for a bit before that tho.
That's the "adjacent" part...And
social work before that for like, a
million years, so ...empathy is
something I'm good at. Now, wasn't
always, longer story. But yeah,
empathy. Don Norman doesn't believe
in it's place in design research,
but I dig it!

Imani chuckles at her own inside joke as Jack's eyes glaze over. He nods then looks to his phone, starts scrolling. He's gone.

JACK
Cool.

IMANI
But I've always been a systems
thinker...

Imani tries to save face and reconnect. Jack checks his phone. Imani, no stranger to abrupt endings, moves on. She mouths "cool" and scans the room until her attention catches.

A YOUNG WOMAN across the room (wearing headphones, clearly) is looking directly at Imani. Discovered, the YOUNG WOMAN pivots her gaze to her computer. Imani quickly and awkwardly follows suit. Despite herself, she looks back, curious and longing for a connection.

IMANI (VO) (CONT'D)
What's it like to be her in this
place...

MED SHOT A finger from behind Imani's shoulder, tap tap tap...

CU slow motion Imani's eyes widen.

SLOW MOTION tapping continues.

CU Slow motion Imani closes her eyes. Make it stop.

Imani drops her shoulder as if she has no bones and slides out of her chair. She re-bones and stands suddenly. Awkwardly smiles. Another recovery attempt.

TODD
(reading off a resume in
his hand)
Are you...Imani?

He looks around the room again.

IMANI
Hi. Yes, that's me.

It's YOUNG MAN 1 with the half beer/half coffee/office speedball. His name is TODD.

TODD
Wow, you are NOT who I was
expecting.

IMANI
Thought I'd be more Irish?

TODD
Imani Washington doesn't
necessarily read white.

Stating the painfully obvious.

IMANI

Well, Im not as white as I read. My mother is Haitian- her dad is the whitest white guy- and so is my dad, so...

Imani circle gestures at her own white facing face then shrugs. Todd peers at Imani.

TODD

Yeah, I'd call you 100% Irish if I had to guess.

It continues.

IMANI

Don't have to. Genetics...

She does jazz hands.

TODD

(not invested)

Fascinating. I'm Todd, head of product. Come on back. HEYY! Jack!!

When Todd turns his attention Imani looks relieved. This type of convo is recurrent and exhausting. Todd and Jack fist bump. An in depth fist bump with several complications. It's rehearsed.

JACK

Long time no see, man. What's it been, like, three days?

TODD

Yeah man, come on by. You know my backyard corn hole has your name on it.

JACK

Dirty. If I had a BitJack for every time I heard THAT.

The two snicker.

TODD

You know it, see you in there.

Imani has a bad feeling.

Tracking shot from behind. She follows Todd through the office past the ping pong and beer taps.

Passed a room with a sign reading "NAPS", someone is asleep on a mat facing away from her. She enters an area partitioned off by building block cubes.

As she enters, she sees the men are all dressed in various forms of khakis and plaid or striped shirts and Stan Smiths.

TODD (CONT'D)
Gentlemen, this is...our first interviewee...Imari...

IMANI
Hi. Imani. With an n.

TODD
Right, sorry. Got a nickname or anything?

IMANI
No. N as in No.

Imani tries to laugh off the weirdness.

TODD
Well, we'll have to figure out what to call you.

1/3 of the men smile politely at Imani, the rest are responding to texts/scrolling Instagram.

TODD (CONT'D)
Cool cool... as everyone here knows, we're nearing the end of our sprint cycle, so we had to switch things up and we're jumping right into our whiteboard challenge with Imami. Then we'll finish the rest of the two hour interview with a paired down crew after this.

Imani's face and spirit collapse.

IMANI
I'd thought... (Imani shuffles the agenda she was given) it says, it reads, there was a meet and greet first, and that there's just a portfolio review for a total of 40 minutes...

TODD

That's the other half of the interview with the research team, We'll get there. Project wants to see you think on your feet. Then you'll meet with the rest of product.

IMANI

(Beat) I think I wasn't sent the whole agenda. I was only sent this one and researchers aren't always asked for a whiteboard challenge so I didn't think...

Imani looks around and grasps to reign in her nervousness and explanations. Going off script isn't her forte.

TODD

Is this a problem for you?

Imani freezes. She's showing her hand again.

IMANI

No, It sounds good.

TODD

Grand.

Todd leaves Imani standing on one side of the table, walks around and sits down so all the men are on the opposite side from her. Some scrolling continues others are silencing their phones.

TODD (CONT'D)

Feel free to put your bags anywhere. You'll be using this whiteboard. This one. To your right. Markers are here.

Still holding everything she came in with, Imani looks around and places her bag on the floor. There's no chair for her. She opens one of the markers and tests it. It's dried out so she tests another...

One of the interviewers pulls two out of his bag and hands her one.

MAN 1

Here, I have a couple extra.

IMANI

Thanks.

He politely nods and hands her the marker. He taps his twice on the table, a nervous tic.

TODD

Okay, Imarsi, this is your challenge...

Todd leans in, he lives, for this moment...

TODD (CONT'D)

Imagine, if you will...

The team chuckles, Todd loves it.

TODD (CONT'D)

...the company has rebooted the website and you're tasked with finding WHERE in the flow...

IMANI

I'm sorry to interrupt, do you have this printed? This exercise?

Off his look she realizes he considers this high maintenance. AND she's ruining his delivery/moment in the sun.

IMANI (CONT'D)

To read.

Todd's palpable irritation persists.

IMANI (CONT'D)

It helps if I can read it, I don't work well from memorization. I mean, not now in a new place...I'm good at memorizing, just not verbal directives...

He doesn't give her any warmth.

IMANI (CONT'D)

...I...I'll... write this down. Let me grab a pen and paper...

Imani grabs pen and paper from her bag and kneels at the desk a la no chair.

TODD

Take your time. You're tasked with finding in the workflow WHERE...

The man who lent Imani the pen is opening and closing the cap on his marker. Her hearing is distorted.

CU slow motion on the cap. The sound echoes thru Imani's skull. Her eyes widen and close. All she can hear is the squawking. As he taps it on the table twice again, it reverberates across the table to her. His eyes twitch nervously.

She stands up. All eyes are on her. She clears her throat and kneels back down.

IMANI

Right, (she struggles to focus and repeats) how would I determine where the user is experiencing their first discomfort, and also where in the flow they eject...

BLACK

INT. OFFICE

Todd is escorting Imani towards the cafe.

TODD

Thanks again for coming in. And please don't hesitate to reach out.

Todd, unsolicited, puts his hand on Imani's back. Moving her towards the door.

IMANI

Yeah I will for sure (beat) I'd like to understand next steps and to get some feedback and whatnot. I'm really looking to understand how to strengthen...

TODD

(interrupts, turns to leave)

Strong. Strength is key. Good instinct.

He taps her back.

TODD (CONT'D)

Don't forget to grab a cold brew refill on the way out and OH!... We have coozies! Take a couple... They're awesome.

IMANI

Thanks...

Todd is already walking away. She raises an eyebrow, shakes her head. The woman with the headphones who had avoided Imani's gaze, hurries by her, her coat on, her lunch bag clutched to her chest. Her one almost life line in her one almost job. Imani watches her go.

EXT. TECH OFFICE IN EL SEGUNDO

Imani rushes from the building. She's on a parking level she doesn't recognize. Where is she? She runs through different floors.

When she finally finds where she *knows* she'd parked -- the car is nowhere to be seen.

She looks left, right. Then, through a partition in the parking structure wall, she sees two more identical parking structures. Panic.

She hauls through the narrow corridors to the furthest structure.

Finally, out of breath, she spots her car. And we see the reason for panic -- DOG. Imani sees GRIF through the hatchback window. He's looking at her, calmly, head on the backseat headrest.

IMANI

Grif, I'm sorry!!!

The windows are rolled down. Cut to interior, he has a bowl of water, some food and a toy. He lazily thumps his tail, happy to see her.

IMANI (CONT'D)

I didn't think it would be so long!
I'm really sorry...

She squeezes in next to him to give him a hug. They get out, walk to the grass and quickly settle in under a tree. Ah, THIS is her lifeline. Comforted.

Imani looks out over the lot.

IMANI (CONT'D)

I don't suspect that worked out,
 Pal. Think they're looking for
 something a little more...standard
 issue. We'll see though, right?
 (beat, remembers) I brought you
 this.

She reaches into her bag and pulls out the coozie. Grif
 sniffs, paws, then chews on it. She looks out and digs a pen
 into the ground.

EXT. ECHO PARK

Shots of Echo Park.

Various styles of homes in close proximity to each other. New
 builds next to bungalows, dogs behind chain link fences with
 yards full of plastic playground toys, juxtaposed tall
 prohibitive fences with sideways oak plank and Helvetica
 numerical stainless steel signs with elaborate intercom
 systems- indicators of a rapidly gentrifying community, gang
 graffiti overlapping rival gangs, an old school taqueria, a
 swanky sneaker store...a housing crisis.

Tents line the park, we see someone bathe their armpits in
 the public sink, someone reaches their hand out of their tent
 to grab a pair of shoes to slip on, a wide shot of the amount
 of tents. Signs point to community members disgruntled with
 council-member (Insert "Ditch Mitch" equivalent bumper
 stickers on the council-member's office doors). Some
 competing "Get the Homeless Out!!" signage...a socioeconomic
 war zone.

Meanwhile up the road...

EXT. STREET VIEW. APARTMENT COMPLEX IN ECHO PARK

EXT. COURTYARD OF APARTMENT BUILDING

Imani and Grif stand in the courtyard of her apartment
 building sizing up a man in his mid forties (same from
 opening) in carpenter pants, flannel shirt, a dirty white t
 shirt and construction boots. He's shifty eyed, talks
 quickly and has more than the slight air of a carnie.

Imani is showing him the tiny ramshackle courtyard space
 after exiting the house

IMANI
...and that's it really...

Imani sweeps her arms gesturing around the location.

IMANI (CONT'D)
The castle.

ROBERT
Great yeah, I like it. I'm
interested, I mean, I'd take it.

Imani feels hopeful.

ROBERT (CONT'D)
I see you're an animal lover, would
you mind if I had my dog sometimes?

Doh. Imani looks down at Grif. Grif looks at her.

IMANI
I guess... he's friendly? My front
neighbor has little dogs.

ROBERT
Yeah she's a real sweetheart.

IMANI
She. What is she? Like, a mix of
stuff? What kind of mix?

ROBERT
She's a German Shepherd. Real
sweet. I bought her off a guy. A
real class act breeder a couple
years ago. She's got papers.

Not a rescue. Imani takes this in and thinks better than to
express as such.

IMANI
Maybe just keep her with you- In
the courtyard?

ROBERT
For sure. Is he a Scottish
Deerhound?

Robert gestures to Grif.

IMANI
Yeah. And some other stuff...

ROBERT
Thought so. They're so cool.

Imani nods.

ROBERT (CONT'D)
Hey, speaking of courtyard, seems like the gardener hasn't come by in a long time, I could go ahead and take care of these plants for you.

Gardener? Imani takes a look around. It's true. The succulents aren't currently thriving.

IMANI
If you want to. Im not real... domestic I guess you'd call it, plant wise. I mean, I water Grif and whatnot because he moves around and has eyes and looks at me and blinks and what have you... But I forget about the plants sometimes.

Imani laughs to make herself less nervous and appear relatable but Robert is oblivious...

ROBERT
I've got a real green thumb. You should see my pansies and marigolds in the Inland Empire. I tell you what, I could work some of that magic here...

Imani nods. It's not entirely awful news.

ROBERT (CONT'D)
Could even do a discount if it looked great. But ya know, we can see about that.

Imani shifts her eyes, unsure of what to say. Recovers.

IMANI
Welp... we both need three months and your schedule works best with mine. So, I guess, it's all yours if you want it.

Robert throws his arms up and draws them down with bent elbows, the international sign for "winner". Like he's won a stuffed bear.

IMANI (CONT'D)
(acknowledging his
enthusiasm)
Woooo.. Yeah. I've never really
sublet it before.

ROBERT
Oh, You won't regret it. Safe and
sound with me.

Imani pulls out her keys unclips the spare set.

IMANI
I usually hide these behind the pot
here so I can get in if I lock
myself out.

Imani moves the pot and we see an imprint in dirt of where
the keys usually live.

IMANI (CONT'D)
I'll just put em here if we cant
meet up before I go.

ROBERT
Ill come meet you.

IMANI
Ok, yeah. I guess I'll be out
tomorrow. Wow. (beat)
It's great that, Angie didn't need
you to sublet her place. I mean,
sorry she didn't need you, but I'm
glad it worked out for us. She met
you thru HOMIES.COM she said?

'ROBERT
Craigslist actually. Last week.

Imani clocks this. She remembers ANGIE'S words...

CUT TO

Imani on phone with ANGIE.

ANGIE
I found him on one of the apps,
Honey, that does background checks,
HOMIES I think. He has a real
worker's spirit, Honey, a real
salty man of the earth. I even
thought he was kinda cute. You
might like him...

MS Imani's interested face listens via earbuds.

CUT TO

Imani's current skeptical face taking this guy in. The cagey carnie, hawking stuffed animal energy.

ROBERT

Man... I'm glad this worked out on such short notice. This location is perfect, central. My gigs for the next month'll, be split between Chatsworth and Sherman Oaks, but my kid is out in the Inland Empire so I'll have to get him on weekends. I'm thinking I'll build a loft bed in the bedroom so he can sleep there- kind of make him his own bedroom or whatever, he's fourteen and all...

IMANI

Loft? ...Fourteen?

Imani looks around the impossibly small courtyard.

IMANI (CONT'D)

Two people?...

Imani regrettably eyes the key location she's just given away.

ROBERT

Yeah my boy... he's a spark plug. We're pretty much on top of each other in the Inland Empire anyway, ha- thats funny- make it literal! If there's anything that'll make a family close...

MS on Robert speaking, his mouth moving quickly but the sound is replaced with a ringing in her ears.

CU on his mouth moving. It's going a mile a minute.

MS Imani is somewhere else.

The chaos Imani's imagination has invented-- Robert yelling at an apathetic teenager. Gesturing broadly with his arms while spilling a beer. The teenager spits on the floor. Her floor. She pictures the strange loft apparatus the man will build.

The weird carnie sex with strangers he'll have while the boy is forced to wait outside, chain smoking into the fire pit, urinating on the plants. Setting things on fire in a disgruntled adolescent testosterone riddled rage...

She snaps to. She looks at him, still talking, his words rushing at her, the dam of her consciousness breached. The ringing stops.

ROBERT (CONT'D)

...then you've got two crossbeams to support it all...pretty straightforward I build up and tear down these kinds of things all the time, it's pretty simple really.

IMANI

Gotcha. (She feels trapped. She can't back out.) I had been really hoping for one person since the place is so small...

Imani tries to get a read on his body language. He doesn't flinch or blink. But she notices his left finger tapping his pants...

CU on Imani eyes

CU his left finger tapping

CU a bead of sweat forming on his temple

CU Imani's eyes as she realizes...

IMANI (V.O.)

He's desperate. You need this. Do it.

IMANI

Ok. Let's maybe talk about rent cost with an extra person...

INT. IMANIS HOUSE NIGHT

Imani is moving about her apartment putting objects in boxes.

PAN the apartment; it's a small space yet well cared for. In an anthropological sentimental way. There are cameras lined on shelves, 16mm, 8mm, old camcorders. A newer Canon 5D. She's clearly into film.

INSERTS; Eclectic decor, some found objects as art, driftwood and natural materials. She is nature loving and retiring. A glimpse at her book titles: film, tech, art, social justice, and philosophy oriented. Pictures of Grif and landscapes in place of family photos on the fridge.

There's a volume of books which is missing a selection. She touches the area of the missing book. She opens a CIGAR BOX and flips through a couple photos. There's faded photos of various people, a couple MAN and WOMAN. The man is white and the woman biracial. She finds a photo of MICHAEL, her ex. There's one of him on a mountain top and the next is a photo of him flipping her off. She puts them back and puts the cigar box into a larger storage box.

She continues to move through the space familiarly, not stepping on a single thing- she's intimate with every inch of the place.

Dissolves into various activities and stages of departure and packing until we find her sitting on the couch with Grif. She stares at the door and remembers...

Shot of Imani in a different outfit, reacting to the sound of the front gate closing followed by the sound of boots on cement. Imani breaks into a wide smile and goes to the door to welcome Michael. Back to the present moment Imani and on her lap- Grif sleeping. A bittersweet memory- she closes her eyes. Dissolve she's asleep.

In the morning, Grif still sleeping on couch, she surveys her place. She gets up and starts stacking the boxes into the closet.

EXT. IMANIS HOUSE

On the patio Imani has a list with todo items crossed off.

PACK is crossed out. STORAGE as well. Next on the list is GYM/SHOWERS. She opens her computer and enters "travel gym membership, showers" and returns with "GYMFIT". The description reads, "The on the go fitness app. In every major city. Download the app!"

IMANI

Perfect.

She downloads the app onto her phone and pulls out her credit card to set up the membership. Crosses "GYM/SHOWERS" off the list.

STREET VIEW. LATE AFTERNOON. APARTMENT COMPLEX IN ECHO PARK

Imani carries duffle bags from the top of the stairs down to the car.

ROBERT

Hey, thanks again. And for letting me pay half the month today and half Friday at that new price...production is late paying me again...super inconvenient. But Friday is the day! Do you want me to watch the dog while you bring your bags down?

Imani looks at Grif. She looks at all the heavy bags she's gonna have to lug down the stairs. She wishes he'd go away, so she could leave in peace. This went all wrong.

IMANI

Sure. Thanks.

ROBERT

You got it.

Robert stares into his phone while Imani awkwardly hefts her bags down the stairs. She grabs a second load and plops them at the bottom. Runs up for a third.

IMANI

(to Grif)

STAY.

She packs the trunk and rearranges a couple of items in the inventory and shuts the hatchback, walks back up the stairs.

IMANI (CONT'D)

I'm set.

ROBERT

Glad I could be helpful.

IMANI

So, text if you need anything. I got this payment here today and I'll look for your next PayPal Friday. In three days.

Imani looks at him to make sure he's paying attention.

ROBERT

I'm good for it. Friday.

Imani shuffles Grif down the stairs. Robert shouts from the balcony.

ROBERT (CONT'D)
Most likely after work, end of day.
Just in case.

Robert waves and lights up a butt watching Imani leave. She's uneasy about him. She's uneasy about any of this.

She gets in the car and pulls out of sight.

Further down the block she pauses to pull out her phone and opens her bank account. She takes stock of the amount. It's not enough to hit the road. She eyes the number in the account.

IMANI
Shit.

EXT. STREET IN ECHO PARK NIGHT

Imani drives around echo park, drives past Echo Park lake.

Imani drives into a hill section of Echo Park. The streets are lined with cars.

It's difficult to find a spot. This won't do.

She drives back down onto Glendale closer to the gym and her favorite French restaurant.

Finally, she kills the lights and parks near the clump of trees between two dark apartment buildings, across the way from the streetlamp with the bulb shot out.

She sits for a moment and looks around.

She pulls out her phone and flips through her contacts. She dials and calls someone. They answer. HEDY (Half Jewish, Half Japanese, nerdy stylish hipster) It's loud.

HEDY
(in the middle of a party)
HEY! I'm at a party! Where are you?
Do you wanna come? Why aren't you
texting? Who calls anymore? Is
something wrong?

'Common People' by Pulp is playing loudly through the phone. Revelers at the party are thrashing and dancing. Some people at the sidelines are smoking. Everyone looks very hip. Hedy is wearing tall Tevas and looks a little nerdy in all the right ways.

IMANI

Oh, uh, no. I just figured I'd try you and say hello.

HEDY

Come to the party! There's a Karaoke Van... "AND DANCE AND DRINK AND SCREW! BECAUSE THERES NOTHING ELSE TO DO!"

Hedy shouts along to the karaoke van lyrics. The people around her are in an ecstatic bacchanalia of their extended youth.

IMANI

Ok, well, I can't really hear you. I mean I can, but that almost seems like a problem.

HEDY

WHAT? COME!!

IMANI

(lackluster)
Ok. I'll come.

HEDY

Liar. And if you did you'd just leave without telling anyone, weirdo. I'm gonna go, I'm up next. I have to smoke a butt to get real raspy.

IMANI

(disappointed)
Ok.

HEDY

Wait, are you going to Max and Martin's Saturday?

IMANI

What? No. What's at Max and Martin's?

HEDY

Oh, shoot. I was supposed to tell you.

IMANI

Thanks.

HEDY

A barbecue. Go! I'm getting there at 10 to set up- I said I'd DJ a set- you can help me.

IMANI

I don't know if I'm up for Max and Martin... I'm kind of out of it and they're so perfect...They scare me.

HEDY

What? They like you. And no one's perfect... aside from Max and Martin.

Takes a drag of her cigarette.

IMANI

Are you smoking??

HEDY

Gotta go! I'm up! See you Saturday- It'll be fun! Byeeeeee!

Hedy hangs up. And dances with the people around her.

Imani's disappointment lives on her face. She texts another friend.

IMANI (TEXT)

Hey, Amon. Feelin pretty weird.
I'm in my car. I had to sublet for
a long time this time...

Imani erases most of text backs up to...

IMANI (TEXT) (CONT'D)

Hey A. What's crackling?

Imani waits a moment. Nothing. Amon is not the best texter. She follows up.

IMANI (TEXT) (CONT'D)

Got a sec to chat?

Imani stares at the screen. She lifts her gaze and looks out at the street. It's a street she knows but the situation is entirely new. A ding.

AMON (TEXT)
Getting ready for a date.

IMANI
Ah ok. Carry on!

Imani inserts a confetti pop. And realizes how distant she is from that gesture.

Silence.

She pulls a water jug from the passenger side floor, fills a metal bowl and puts it down in back for Grif.

She puts on a scarf, more for reassurance than cold, adjusts the rearview mirror, pulls out a wool blanket from the back and sits.

Listening to street sounds, she again considers her phone. There's no one to call. She sets it down. From the front pouch of her backpack she pulls out MACE and places it under her leg. She leans her chair back slightly, reconsiders, and brings it back up, shuts her eyes, opens them again and closes them. After all these new and foreign little rituals she tried to rest.

OVERHEAD

The exterior of Imani's car. Next to the apartments. Next to some tents on the side streets of Echo Park. A street light flickers.

BLACK

DAWN. Same overhead shot. Imani pulls the car away out of frame.

INT. GAS STATION

Sound edit will be underwater sounding

There's an assortment of characters in the store. A man whose pants are falling low shuffles through. Someone in a Range Rover pulls up and gestures that their pump doesn't work. A general urban hustle and bustle.

Imani is bleary eyed walking around the store. She fills her thermos and pays for a coffee at the register.

The man holding up his pants is outside now and asks her for spare change. She pulls the quarter out of the pile for herself and gives him the rest of the change.

CUT TO:

EXT. ELYSIAN PARK

Underwater sound continued

Imani and Grif pass thru their usual neighborhood park. She sips her coffee. Look "natural". Her eyes are bloodshot and nervous.

She says hello and raises her mug at a couple people. Theater. Someone says her name and pats Grif. She's on edge and near tears. She hides it. She smiles nervously and laughs.

IMANI

He's the easiest guy!!

She waves and laughs as the people pass by. She's hiding in plain sight. Her smile drops as soon as no one can see.

BLACK

INT. BATHROOM TAIX

Imani exits a toilet stall of a local french restaurant and washes her hands.

The wallpaper is ornate and textured. She runs her hand along feeling the grooves.

She passes thru the hallway, slightly less decadent. She smiles at the maitre d. He waves before turning to his waitstaff.

EXT. PARKING LOT AFTERNOON

She exits the restaurant and cuts thru the parking lot where she's parked. Close to where she'd parked the previous evening.

Below the parking there's a TENT CITY.

As she approaches the car, she spies a YOUNG PERSON. The young person also sees Imani.

Imani flinches slightly then puts on a smile. Gotta pull it together. The young person walks over to Imani's car for a greeting.

YOUNG PERSON

Hey.

IMANI

Heya. Thought I recognized the hair, looks good.

The young person runs their hand through their half shaved half purple cut.

YOUNG PERSON

Yeah, I feel like a million bucks. I'd also take a million bucks. But I'll take what I can get.

IMANI

No doubt.

Imani catches a glimpse of another person in the young person's tent. They have books open and appear to be studying.

YOUNG PERSON

You remember Mannie? We've been staying down here lately, we got swept from the park. It's like they just don't want us to be able to shit in a real fucking toilet and wash after. I don't fucking get it. Someone brought these hand washing stations the other day tho.

YP gestures to the plastic contraption. It's already tagged with graffiti.

IMANI

Oh that's great.

YOUNG PERSON

Yeah. Anyway they're cramming. They've got a test next week. Physiology. It's bullshit... lose your place to live with a test coming up...

IMANI

Man...With a physiology test coming?

YOUNG PERSON

Yeah. They're trying to go pre med.

Imani considers this.

YOUNG PERSON (CONT'D)

We're saving up for a car. Mostly cause sometimes the community college will let students stay in the parking lot. Kind of unofficially tho...

IMANI

Really?? Wow...that's great.

YOUNG PERSON

Yeah.

YP is looking at Imani's car which is full of belongings.

IMANI

Camping trip...headed out of town soon...

YOUNG PERSON

Yeah...

The two exchange an awkward beat.

YOUNG PERSON (CONT'D)

You still working at Hampton House social working? ...I kinda blew out of there the last time.

IMANI

...it happens, you had a lot going on. I know they'd always be happy to chat with you if you needed a place to stay. I'm not actually (Beat) still there. I left to kind of take a crack at something different. Getting into Tech. It's like social work tech, systems stuff. Trying to make systems easier to navigate... Like, make the medi-cal site easier to use...

YOUNG PERSON

No shit. That's dope. That shit is fucked up to try to get healthcare. I think you helped me sign up.

IMANI

Yeah exactly! It shouldn't be so hard. Like, you shouldn't need someone who does that kind of thing all day to show you how to use it. So, that sort of thing. Fix how stuff works.

YOUNG PERSON

Tight. I thought you were in Film School?

Imani averts her gaze momentarily.

IMANI

No, thats not for me...

Young person picks up on an awkward feeling and looks towards Imani's car.

IMANI (CONT'D)

Yeah, so, Gonna do a little camping tho before I really pound the pavement and start applying (beat) They offer scholarships you know, the tech bootcamp, if you ever want to apply for one. I think you'd be really good at that sort of thing.

YOUNG PERSON

Yeah I don't know. Sounds good for you. But thanks for looking out for me.

Imani's hopes feel dashed. She'd wanted to be helpful but instead feels like she missed the mark.

YOUNG PERSON (CONT'D)

Hey ya know,...I saw you parked down there (gestures)last night...You shouldn't park there tonight, it's Friday, there's, like, rival gang activity here on the weekends...see the tags?

Imani and YP look around at the different tags on the block. There's several tags with others drawn over them.

YOUNG PERSON (CONT'D)
...and police...but... you're
white, so you should be okay..."

Imani's gaze drops. A flash of a memory. She is riding in the car with her parents. Her father is in the drivers seat. Her mother looks nervous. They are waiting patiently. They've been pulled over by an officer and he approaches the vehicle bringing back her father's ID card.

OFFICER
No problems here today. Just get
that tail light fixed and watch
your speed through here.

FATHER
Thank you.

OFFICER
And thank you for your service.

FATHER
Thank you, Officer.

The officer looks at Imanis mother then looks back at Imani before walking away. Imani's father turns to her mother.

MOTHER
Eesh. What a creep.

FATHER
I didn't think he was so bad.

MOTHER
Yeah well... he ran your license
after seeing me.

FATHER
Routine I'm sure.

Imani's mother looks unconvinced.

FATHER (CONT'D)
Pays for itself that Marine Corps
sticker...

MOTHER
Seems to. And being white...

FATHER
(Turns to Imani in backseat/camera)
And don't ever talk back to an
officer, Imani.

MOTHER

Ever.

Young Imani holding a Smurffette toy. Eyes wide.

Imani flashes back to the present moment. She chooses her battles and decides to say nothing. She nods. Imani feels exposed and misunderstood all at once. Most of all she's trying to maintain a professional decorum.

YOUNG PERSON

Well, good luck with the job stuff
and maybe see ya around here. Lemme
know if you need anything.

Imani is a little speechless. This wasn't how she imagined this talk going. This wasn't how she imagined her life going. She wants to be humble and honor this person's wisdom. She feels alone and afraid.

She can only manage a weak wave as YOUNG PERSON returns to meet their friend back at the tent. Imani collects herself and returns to the car.

INT. CAR

Imani puts in her headphones, dials and waits. Her concerned looking face shifts into a friendly and lighter one and a jolly voice rings thru the other end.

KEITH

Hey!

IMANI

(puts on a chipper voice)
Hey Keith!

Cut to INT. KEITH'S HOUSE

KEITH is 75ish years old. His house is a menagerie of animals, birds squawking, cats on tables, several dogs running under foot. Photos of Imani and Grif pinned to a wall are among other colorful photos and historical sports clippings, "Celtics Champs!" A sentimental fellow.

KEITH

Good to hear ya! How's sunny
California?

IMANI
It's sunny.

KEITH
(laughs)
Makes sense! How's old boy Grif?

IMANI
Aw, he's good. Handsome. Bearded.

Imani looks around at Grif, who does look good, handsome and bearded. Happy to be with Imani.

IMANI (CONT'D)
I have a few days off in a row so we're gonna do a camping trip. He deserves it.

KEITH
He sure does. That'll be nice. Hey, how's the new job?

IMANI
Keith, I'm gonna pop my headphones in, one sec.

Imani pauses and looks around. Her eyes fall towards the tent camp and she starts the car.

IMANI (CONT'D)
Ok there, couldn't hear you so well, back now. Yeah, we're doing well! We'll probably go up the coast to camp. Beautiful up there, I'll send some photos if you ever figure out how to check your email.

Keith chuckles.

KEITH
Yeah, we haven't quite mastered that without you. I'll have to figure out how to log in.

IMANI
Haha. How's Sandra doing? Tell her I said hello

KEITH

Good Good! So helpful for us.
Sandra, it's Imani. She says hello!

SANDRA, Keith's assistant pulls her head out of a bird cage to shout.

SANDRA

Hello, Imani!

KEITH

Yep, we're glad she could come on to help.

IMANI

Me too. How's it goin over there.

KEITH

Well, we had one kitten with a broken paw come in... Sally. She's a good girl, settling in.

Sally hobbles after another cat trying to thwap them.

KEITH (CONT'D)

But other than that we've been pretty quiet, same crew. Oh, we did have birds keep flying into the window...

IMANI

Ooof. Yeah?

KEITH

Yeah, that got everyone going. So we put up a couple stickers and a windscreen of a cat(Keith laughs). Seems to have fixed things. Give something for the bird to look at anyway.

IMANI

(genuinely impressed)
Wow, good thinking!

Imani switches gears.

IMANI (CONT'D)

How have you been feeling lately?

Imani's face grows serious.

KEITH

(still light)

Well, ya know, the dizzy spells are kind of coming and going a bit. We moved my room to the first floor to avoid the stairs, doesn't help that I'm tripping all over cats everywhere.

A cat runs under Keiths wheelchair as another sits on his lap.

KEITH (CONT'D)

But someone's gotta run this cathouse, better be us. Chemo's going well tho.

Keith adds the last quickly, not one to dwell on what he can't fix. Imani abides.

IMANI

I'm glad to hear that. And I'm glad you found someone who can help out over there since I left.

Imani looks guilty.

KEITH

Yeah, Sandra has been doing great for the rescue here

Sandra has her entire torso in the giant bird cage behind Keith still. She shouts a thanks from deep inside and continues cleaning.

KEITH (CONT'D)

And we're just glad you're out there living that big California life. Rocky starts are normal. But you've got this job now and were proud of you for sticking it out.

Imani looks around uncomfortably.

IMANI

Thanks for the help before, with rent those times. It really was above and beyond.

KEITH

Don't mention it. How's your mom doing these days?

IMANI

I don't actually know. I haven't heard from her in a long time.

KEITH

Did you try to reach her?

IMANI

No.

KEITH

Well... that's ok too.

IMANI

Yeah...

Imani looks foggy. Keith begins to cough and Sandra pulls herself out of the cockatiel cage to assist him.

IMANI (CONT'D)

I should let you rest.

KEITH

Well, it's good to hear from you. I should call more, I know.

IMANI

It's ok. Not easy running a cathouse. I gotta go to a meeting at my tech bootcamp anyway. Celebratory stuff. Rest up.

KEITH

(chuckles at his own joke
adopted)

Good good. Ok, bye bye now.

Imani hangs up the phone. Takes a look around. She bites her nails and stares into the middle distance.

EXT. TECH BOOTCAMP

Imani arrives at EXPERIENCE ACADEMY, a tech bootcamp. She spies all the familiar sights, excellent graphic design stickers, clean white surfaces, a lot of trendy looking students in doc martens. Free coffee, tea and breath mints. She walks by an office that looks empty then makes her way over to the front desk area.

IMANI

Hi. I have an appointment with,
Chris, "Jobs Coach Chris" not the
other one at 11:30.

A fretful face from the front desk person.

FRONT DESK CLERK

Oh...He didn't call you?

IMANI

What? No...

FRONT DESK CLERK

He actually isn't with us
anymore...

IMANI

I had an appointment...I haven't
been able to find work, my loan
repayments are starting and we were
going to talk through what more I
could do to land a job...like
rework my resume...

FRONT DESK CLERK

Yeah. I'm sorry.

IMANI

It's so sudden... when will someone
replace him?

FRONT DESK CLERK

I don't actually know. We just
posted the job along with a
financial counselor job.

IMANI

Ok. I'll just ...have a seat for a
bit.

FRONT DESK CLERK

I'm sorry. You could apply here?

Imani considers. The clerk makes a hopeful face and wanders
off to replenish stickers and tea. Imani takes a seat in the
lobby. She looks around with familiarity and we see her
process the idea.

IMANI

Why not?

She opens her laptop and types in the browser. EXPERIENCE ACADEMY | JOBS. She scrolls down past the "JOB COACH" position after scrunching her nose- that one wouldn't be right for her. "FINANCIAL COUNSELOR" could be good... she clicks.

Her eyes scan the job description and then...they catch. A look of discomfort flashes. The phrase directly under "FINANCIAL COUNSELOR" reads, "a sales position focused on..." Imani places her laptop on the counter and sits back. She stands and walks over to the front desk clerk.

IMANI (CONT'D)

Heya...the financial advisor position... is that a sales position? I just read that it's a sales position. That can't be right. When I applied, my financial advisor told me I probably wouldn't qualify for a scholarship. I didn't apply for a scholarship because he said I wouldn't get it.... Do you see what I'm saying?

The front desk clerk looks confused.

It's a sales position and not a counselor position? He discouraged me from applying. I applied for a giant ass loan because a salesman who got a cut of my sale told me I wouldn't get help if I applied. I have loan repayments starting that I could've avoided? I can't stay at my house... he was a salesman and not a counselor?

FRONT DESK CLERK

(discomfort growing)

Sorry, I'm not sure...

The front desk person starts to understand what Imani is laying out. It's above their pay grade. Imani knows this and feels powerless.

IMANI

I'm... I'm gonna go. I have no idea what to do. Have a good day here.

The clerk watches Imani go unsure of what to do.

EXT GYM TWILIGHT

Imani sitting in her car, looks at the time, 6:45, checks in on her gym app phone, tucks Griff in, then exits the car and heads inside.

INT. GYM SHOWER

Imani bows her head under a shower nozzle in the women's locker room of the fitness club. Gets distracted by some nearby noises.

Getting dressed at a locker, she carefully wipes her feet after taking off her rubber flip flops. She slips on some socks. She grimaces as the rubber squeaks as she washes the flip flops.

She shoves a travel-sized toothpaste and a handful of tampons from the wash area into her bag. On her way out the door she addresses the attendant.

IMANI

Goodnight.

The attendant continues their work with headphones on oblivious to Imani. A clock above the attendant reads 7pm.

The door closes and the camera stays with the attendant for a beat. Nodding along to their music, playing whatever game was popular on phones in 2017. Angry Birds.

EXT. NIGHT. OUTDOOR COFFEE SHOP

Imani sits with Griff at her side. She has her empty mug at the table with her for show.

She is composing a follow up email for her job interview... "Thank you again for the opportunity to interview..." We see her thoughtfully compose her letter, make some edits and just as she's finishing up...

BARISTA

Hi, Ma'am. We're closing up now.

IMANI

Oh sorry. I thought you were open til 10.

BARISTA

Yeah. It's 10.

IMANI

Sorry. I don't usually...

BARISTA

Cool dog. Is that an Irish
Wolfhound?

IMANI

Yeah. He's a great guy.

BARISTA

Yeah?

Barista makes sweetie faces at Grif.

IMANI

Thanks for chatting with us.

The Barista looks a little confused and walks away leaving Imani to pack up. Imani doesn't clock her own awkwardness. The cursor blinks as Imani absently closes the computer on the unfinished email.

INT. NIGHT IMANIS CAR

Imani pulls around the Hill section of Elysian Heights looking for a quiet spot to park. She has some luck and is relatively close to a street lamp but just far enough to not be too well lit.

She goes thru the same routine with Grif, takes him out for a pee then climbs back in to settle in. After the ritual is complete she pulls the blanket out and settles back.

BLACK

BAM BAM BAM BAM

INT. IMANIS CAR

Imani is awakened by loud knocks on her car window. There's light flooding in. She's terrified, startled. She pulls out her mace.

It begins to register...the police. Flashlights blur her vision. She can't see. She freezes unsure what to do. The officer drops his face to the window and takes in the scene. He speaks loudly.

OFFICER
Ma'am... I'm gonna need you to roll
down the window.

Imani puts the mace under her leg.

OFFICER (CONT'D)
Ma'am?

Imani is terrified. She rolls down the window.

IMANI
I'm sorry, I didn't know who you
were.

OFFICER
Can I ask what you're doing here?

IMANI
I locked myself out of my
apartment.

The officer moves the flashlight thru the vehicle. The car is
full of belongings. He flashes it back onto her face.

OFFICER
Which one is yours?

IMANI
Well, this isn't my street, I drove
to a friends but I got lost. I
pulled over because I got tired.

OFFICER
Right, you're gonna need to move
along.

IMANI
I thought it would be better to
rest than drive tired.

OFFICER
I said you're going to need to move
along.

IMANI
I..Im not sure where I should go.

This isn't a lie. The officer stands.

OFFICER
Wait right here.

Imani immediately regrets saying so much.

The officer sits in his car, while Imani nervously shifts. Why did she talk back? He walks back after some time.

OFFICER (CONT'D)
You have several unpaid tickets.
Have you been drinking?

IMANI
No, Sir.

Imani swallows the urge to speak more. Unpaid tickets have nothing to do with drinking. She doesn't want to say this. But the conflation gnaws at her.

IMANI (CONT'D)
Money is just tight.

The officer flashes the light in Imani's face again and thru the car. He shines it at Grif.

OFFICER
I could call you in right now. Or
give you another ticket.

Imani stays silent.

OFFICER (CONT'D)
If you cant afford tickets then
maybe Los Angeles isn't right for
you. Move along.

The officer stands.

OFFICER (CONT'D)
(walking away)
Try Riverside drive.

Imani turns on the car and leaves before there's any more trouble.

The lights on the freeway overpass throw yellow lights and shadows across Imani's face as she drives along Riverside Drive. A community of parked caravans and mostly men walking between camps. She passes what appears to be an arrest of a disheveled woman about her own age. Imani sees this and knows by contrast she got off easy. Sorrow. She drives.

BLACK

EXT. MORNING HOUSE IN SILVERLAKE

Imani pulls in front of the beautiful Silverlake home of Max and Martin. She puts the car in park and debates for a moment. She puts the car into gear when she receives a text.

HEDY (TEXT)

@ Max and Martin's setting up. They
took Phoebe out to park- come and
help me!

She gathers her strength and heads in. She approaches a small Hedy trying to lift a very large folding table

HEDY (CONT'D)

That was fast! Were you right
outside? Help me open this...

Hedy peers at Imani without her glasses, she sees that Imani's eyes are red. She looks like hell. Hedy laughs stands and puts her glasses on.

HEDY

Do you have pink eye? You gotta
stop touching stranger's butts?

Upon closer inspection she realizes something is wrong.

HEDY (CONT'D)

Oh no, Imani... Are you ok?

EXT. SILVER LAKE HOUSE

Hedy and Imani sit on the curb.

HEDY

...Oooooof, what did you do after
the cop left?

IMANI

I drove around for a most of the
night... then I, I remembered...I
drove to a community college and
parked in the lot. I didn't see
anyone else there but i heard it
was maybe ok. I don't know...

HEDY
(interrupts)
What? Jesus. That's awful. I'm
sorry. Why didn't you call?

Imani throws her hands up.

IMANI
What are YOU gonna do, you don't
have room. Who has room? You have
roommates. I only really know a
couple people in LA...

HEDY
Max and Martin TOTALLY have a spare
room...

IMANI
I CAN NOT bother Max and Martin.
They've got Phoebe and I don't even
know them. They're *your* friends.
And they're so put together and I'm
so fucked up right now. I cant
bother acquaintances, Hedy. I don't
even want to talk to you about
this. It's too much.

Hedy considers this but doesn't totally relate. She's looking
for a place to insert her opinion.

HEDY
Eesh. I dunno. You moved out of
your place and you're moving to the
woods? I don't like this...

IMANI
I was gonna camp in the BLM land
above SF, apply to jobs from Napa,
they have all those wine tasting
Vineyards lounge rooms...and then
drive into town for interviews. I
have a fitness app for gyms to use
for showers and THOSE bougey gyms
let you bring dogs in. Especially
in the bay. I think I can do it and
still look respectable. I can pull
it off.

Hedy makes a face of concern.

HEDY

How much are you getting for your sublet?

IMANI

Well, you know, I moved in a long time ago so I only pay 800 a month...

HEDY

YOU PAY 800 A MONTH?!

IMANI

SHHH... yes. And I was barely getting by as a social worker. I qualify for food stamps working full time.

HEDY

That's not right.

IMANI

The going rate for a one bedroom now is 1600, so I figure, I can sublet to some hipster trust fund, the neighborhood has already gone to shit and gentrified, I don't have to feel too guilty about just trying to get by. I don't know, it doesn't feel right but I don't have any options. I was supposed to be gone already but my subletter is paying me the rest tomorrow. Turns out I couldn't find a trust fund so fast so I lowered the price and am pretty much breaking even with this trip.

HEDY

Dang.

IMANI

Yeah. I couldn't leave yet...I just can't risk being hundreds of miles away and only having 400 dollars in the bank, I need the rest. I haven't been able to find work since I got out of the tech bootcamp. Im not that close with... with anyone. I mean, Im just not. Anymore.

HEDY

You DO like your space. And you're still hurting from Michael...

Hedy thinks she may have put her foot in her mouth. Imani's face says she's right.

HEDY (CONT'D)

Let me think... I know so many people. Especially up in the bay. I may know someone. You can't get pulled over by the police again. Ugh. I gotta get in and set up. Can you stay for brunch? I know you don't like to mingle...

Imani shakes her head.

IMANI

I just need a job at the party.

HEDY

Can you be the videographer?

IMANI

You know I don't do that anymore...

HEDY

Right, sorry I forgot.
Today you're DJ on deck.

EXT. SILVER LAKE PATIO- AFTERNOON

Silver Lake brunch is in full swing. There's a casual monied vibe, expensive looking vintage, cloth satchels with farmers market goods arrive, two of the dogs have mohawks, the sunglasses have pink lenses.

Hedy chats with MAX and MARTIN, a handsome couple who indeed look perfect. MAX (50s, handsome, black, very stylish with hints of nerdy intellectual) holds toddler PHOEBE as MARTIN (late 30s, handsome ethnically ambiguous, even more stylish and not the least bit nerdy) coos and bubbles to PHOEBE.

Flash throughout the room to see fashion and Los Angeles excess.

Imani, tucked behind some speakers, is down on the ground petting a dog with a pink tail.

IMANI
(holding dog's tail)
Did you ask for this?

The dog runs away and hops into it's owners lap.

IMANI (CONT'D)
Guess so...

Imani, on DJ duty, pushes play on Steve Reich experimental music. Hedy eyes her from across the room shaking her head. Imani mouths the words, "Too far?". Hedy nods. Imani fades it out and fades in William Onyeabar 'Fantastic Man'. People start grooving.

IMANI (CONT'D)
Thought so.

Imani goes back to the dogs.

From under the table. Imani sees stylish shoes attached to a woman she then recognizes, JAIME. Shit. She tries to remain small and low, but is spotted.

Jaime smiles. Imani responds in kind, stands and gestures to the music and starts shuffling through the selections. Jaime keeps looking at Imani, continuing her convo with the people she's speaking with. Hedy clocks the discomfort and grabs drinks for herself and Imani.

HEDY
Refreshment?

IMANI
Please.

Imani grabs both drinks from Hedy, places them on the table for a moment, cues up CAN and promptly leaves the DJ table with both drinks attempting to evade communication with...anyone.

Jaime takes notice of the opportunity and approaches Imani. Hedy looks around for backup. Max smiles as he turns to chat with Jaime and Imani who Jaime has intercepted. He comes in for the save. Imani doesn't realize.

MAX
Jaime, Imani, good to see you both,
how have you been?

JAIME

Max, you look like dee-lish, I see
parenthood isn't slowing you down
at all.

Max is buff. Imani gags at the body comment and does not fix
her face.

MAX

Gotta balance the hospital nights
and the home nights with something.
It's a full moon so we've been
especially busy.

JAIME

Is that a real thing? Full Moons,
people losing it?

IMANI

Yeah.

MAX

Oh yes.

Imani sees an exit from the convo and promptly seizes it.

IMANI (CONT'D)

Max, where's your restroom? I can
never find it.

MAX

Downstairs...fourth door on the
left.

IMANI

(obtusely, more to herself
than anyone else)
Fourth door. Wow.

Imani walks away. MAX continues to chat with Jaime. Jaime
makes a face as if to say "wtf? typical". Max shrugs and
politely smiles at Jaime. He splashes a glance at Martin and
Hedy. Hedy looks disappointed that Imani missed the chance to
talk with Max. Martin bounces Phoebe.

Imani makes her way to the restroom, counting doors.

IMANI (CONT'D)

(to herself)
Fourth door. Firth of Fourth lore.
Mordoor.

She enters the bathroom and sits quietly on the toilet. Clothed. For a few moments, running the water, she watches the water flow for some time before needlessly flushing. She takes a deep breath in. Exhales and exits.

In a new quiet corner of the party IMANI sits on the floor with all the dogs, they've made their way to her. A WOMAN spilling a drink approaches IMANI.

WOMAN

(flirty)

Are you a dog whisperer. I've always wanted to see how it's done.

IMANI

Maybe. Depends on what language the dog speaks.

WOMAN

What do you mean?

IMANI

It's a joke.

The woman suddenly laughs. Imani looks uncomfortable.

IMANI (CONT'D)

Animals are a lot easier to understand.

WOMAN

Than?

IMANI

Hummus.

WOMAN looks confused.

IMANI (CONT'D)

Than everything. It's easy. This guy is happy and social...the tail...

She gestures to Grif who is making friends by sitting near people with food and merrily wagging his tail.

IMANI (CONT'D)

...this guys a little hungry, this girl is nervous because she doesn't like feet...

A little dog stays under the table. She nips at a shoe that comes too close.

IMANI (CONT'D)

She probably got stepped on once.
Sometimes something is a little
more complex, but its usually easy
to figure out if you pay attention
or just listen for a minute.

The woman looks bored. Drunk. Both.

WOMAN

Excuse me, I need to get a drink.
Jenny!...

Woman wanders off towards the makeshift bar to chat with
...anyone else. Imani, used to a sudden departure, saunters
over to the food and takes a few carrots when she is
enveloped by Hedy and a couple friends.

HEDY

This is Imani. Imani this is Kendra
and Phil?

Phil nods. Hedy mouths the word 'TECH'

HEDY (CONT'D)

BRB.

KENDRA (any ethnicity/age) is a little drunk also. KEN (any
ethnicity/age) politely stands by. Kendra points at Imani
and starts making a turn table record scratch gesture

KENDRA

Nice DJ skills. How long have you
known Hedy?

IMANI

A bit. It's hard to keep track. We
met at the dog park maybe a couple
years ago. My dog Grif...

KENDRA

OH! I think you're the friend with
the dog she was just telling us
about...you lost your housing...I'm
sorry. I cant imagine... so you got
evicted?

Imani is taken aback. She's scrambling to cover and not draw
any attention.

IMANI

Evicted? No... I'm subletting for a bit...

KENDRA

Oh thank God. Right, she said you couldn't find work and you had to give up your house. She brought it up because, well, I work in tech also... Im in product development... she said you were in research? Where did you go to school?

IMANI

I finished a tech bootcamp recently.

Kendra nods and sips her drink and looks around the room. She's not going to vouch for someone from a bootcamp.

KENDRA

You had to sublet, God. Is there anyone you can ask for help? A parent or anything?

Imani feels exposed, unsure of how this all started and why its suddenly a party favor convo. She's starting to get defensive and a little louder despite herself...

IMANI

I'm 39 years old, I'm an adult. I don't have *parents* to ask for help. Do you ask your parents for help?

Imani doesn't consider this a real question. But the couple nod. Imani is exasperated. She looks around, she sees that JAIME is in earshot and has heard the whole conversation.

KENDRA

Do you have a place to go?

Imani has had enough. She's overwhelmed and reflexively bites at a hangnail.

IMANI

Excuse me...

Imani collects Grif, who has been making socialization rounds at the party, and makes her way to the door. Hedy spots her and hurries over.

HEDY
Hey, I'm working on connecting you
t...

IMANI
(interrupts)
By telling them my life story?

HEDY
What?

IMANI
C'mon, Hed. I was just accosted by
two people who asked me why I was
homeless and why I didn't ask for
money from my parents? Why does
ANYONE know what's happening in my
life right now?

Hedy's face drops.

HEDY
UGH. Im, so sorry, Imani. I didn't
think she'd repeat any of that. I
just knew she was in tech and
thought I'd mention...

IMANI
Yeah she said as much...

HEDY
Argh, I'm sorry. Please don't go,
we can figure this out.

Imani nervously chews on the inside of her mouth and looks
scattered. They both look at the two dogs staring at them
wondering what's wrong. Hedy looks embarrassed and Imani
switches from chewing her mouth back her nail beds.

HEDY (CONT'D)
Can I give you a hug?

IMANI
No. I don't know. Ok.

Hedy embraces Imani and Imani endures it. Her arms flattened
to her sides. The dogs relax. The two women sit on the
sidewalk.

IMANI (CONT'D)
Tomorrow is Friday and I'll be able
to head north to SF tomorrow when I
get the rest of the rent.

Hedy makes a face.

IMANI (CONT'D)

Look, I cant stay in Los Angeles
(BEAT). Police, gangs, fucking
hipsters, (gestures around the
party)... it's not safe. I'm better
in the woods. I'm good at camping.
And being alone.

Another Hedy face.

HEDY

I know you're used to doing things
alone but, let me help. Or try
anyway... let me ask Max or let me
ask around.

Imani wriggles around uncomfortably.

HEDY (CONT'D)

(guiltily)

I did think of a guy earlier up
north and shot him a text.

Imani hates this.

HEDY (CONT'D)

I said only what I needed to. I'm
waiting to hear back. His name is
Andy Smalls. A real stand up guy.
A LOT of energy. SO much energy.

Imani looks around, defeated. Considers the crowd.

IMANI

He's not a hipster is he?
Because...

Imani gestures around the room. Hedy shakes her head.

HEDY

Not in the slightest.

Imani and Hedy laugh. Hedy side squeezes Imani. She knows
it's a lot to accept help.

JAIME steps outside and walks over to Hedy and Imani.

JAIME

A real swinging time, great set list. Hedy... Mind if I chat with Imani for a sec?

HEDY

My duties require me.

Hedy pats Imani's knee and gives a long glance as she walks away.

IMANI braces herself to talk with JAIME. JAIME appears cool calm and collected.

JAIME

Long time no see.

IMANI

Yeah, it's been ...a minute.

JAIME

Listen, I heard you don't have a place to go and if you need to crash somewhere tonight, I still have the back house open. It's probably not your first choice but, as you know, it's there. You can use it tonight.

The thought sends a visible pang through Imani but she steels herself.

IMANI

I'll take you up on it. Grif would come to.

JAIME

Of course. I'm going to say goodbye to some people but feel free to come by after 7. K?

IMANI

Yeah. Thanks, Jaime.

Jaime nods and walks inside. Imani takes in all of this info and sits to pet Grif. She receives a text.

HEDY (TEXT)

He said reach out when you're up north! Contact: Andy Smalls

EXT. NIGHT -HOUSE IN MOUNT WASHINGTON

Imani stands outside her car and unloads a back pack from the trunk. She looks up at the house and braces herself.

Music -undecided plays over the scene-

She rings the doorbell. Nervous. Covering. She's greeted by Jaime who lets her in. Music plays as we see her enter the space. Jaime gestures to the back door and Imani exits and steps outside.

Imani **numbly** (the whole scene she will have a detached numbness) approaches a small back house. She walks along the cement patio and lingers. She pauses at the door then enters.

She takes in the space and Grif runs in and immediately jumps onto a chair in the corner. He knows this place well. Imani sets her bag down on the corner of the bed and walks into the bathroom.

She looks at herself in the familiar mirror then opens the bathroom cabinet. There's a disposable Bic razor there that she picks up and examines. There's some short bristly hairs in it. A pang of emotion. She carries it with her to the top of the toilet where she sets it down.

She opens the shower curtain and sees a Dr. Bronner's soap bottle. She expected to see it. She lets the shower curtain close.

She makes her way back out to the bedroom where she takes a look around and eyes a book in the corner of the room. It's the missing volume from her place. She picks it up and holds it to her chest. She is surprised to see it and disappointed...

Then she sees a SCULPTURE on a small pedestal by the door. Shock. She sits and regards it heavily. A sudden discomfort, and realization...neither were left by mistake. Anger grips her then and Imani makes her way back to the patio where Jaime is having a drink.

IMANI

Hey thanks for letting us stay.
Mind if I grab a glass?

Jaime gestures towards glasses beneath the wine, already walking towards them. Imani doesn't see Jaime's irritation with Imani's forwardness.

JAIME

So, how have you been?

IMANI

Ya know, fine. Right as rain, good as gold. Stuff like that. How's work? Any discoveries?

Imani takes a drink.

JAIME

Ok yeah. Work is great right now.

Imani prepares herself. Ready for some kind of onslaught. She takes a bigger drink.

JAIME (CONT'D)

I don't know if Michael had mentioned the last advancement before he left...

IMANI

Yeah, something about a robot.

Imani pounds the rest of her drink.

IMANI (CONT'D)

Light pour...oops.

Imani help herself to another round.

JAIME

Yeah, we added a new machine to the arsenal thats really tackling some interesting challenges.

IMANI

Tell me all about it.

Imani centers herself but loses focus. She's looking at Jaime but the room is closing in on her. Anxiety. She hides it by attempting to look engaged. She's trying. Until...

****PING. Cuts through the haze. She reflexively glances down at her phone. An email from TECH COMPANY.

Imani looks back up at Jaime who is speaking then without looking down quickly slides the mail open.

JAIME

...advancements we weren't even expecting...

Imani nods as Jaime talks.

EMAIL

Thank you for your recent inquiry into TECH COMPANY. We regret to inform...

Imani's hearing blurs- Jaime is speaking but its inaudible to Imani. She stands to pour herself a drink, her vision narrows and she sits back down in slow motion- takes a swig. Jaime is watching Imani, shakes her head and also gets up to pour herself a drink. Imani drops back down into the present moment.

IMANI

Sorry, I got distracted for a second.

JAIME

Yeah.

Jamie is put out. Imani prepares to call it a night when the conversation with Jamie darkens.

JAMIE

So, do you want to know how Michael's doing at his fellowship?

IMANI

No.

Jaime's fed up.

JAMIE

This is his life's work you know. What he really cares about...

IMANI

Yes, Im familiar. I was there when he left to go pursue it.

Imani's dry dismissal is too much for Jaime.

JAMIE

The man is a genius and you're too selfish to even be happy for him? You think he should've given that up for you?

I don't get you. You know what, actually I do. You walk around self righteous, judging, aloof. Oh, I'm an artist. Meanwhile you're too afraid to even try. What were you in film school for a year before you quit? You made one short that Michael made the music for? I get you. You cant possibly be happy for anyone because you're too miserable in yourself. You're the one who decided to quit film school because you were afraid to fail, but you'd rather blame Michael.

IMANI

I dropped out of film school to get into tech to support Michael. You think genius and academia make money, Jaime? I left school to take care of us.

JAMIE

Well, any of us including Michael could've, and did, tell you *that* was an idiotic idea. A man like that is solely focused on making his dream a reality. How could you not realize he would lose respect for you. You gave up "the dream", Imani. And you know why, because it's a dream. Make believe. You're a poseur, Imani.

Jaime stands to leave.

JAIME

And I gotta say, I didn't really expect you to come over empty handed. Not listening, disinterested- not surprising but empty handed...

Jamie laughs sarcastically.

JAIME

Vacuum the dog hair before you leave in the morning. I don't think Michael would ever say it to your face, we both know he's too busy to invest the time, but, like, someone's gotta give you the feedback, you make wreckage everywhere you go...you're self absorbed, Imani. It's tiring.

Imani is floored, she isn't sure how to respond, she is momentarily stoic, processing. Jamie walks from the patio chair to the door.

IMANI

Enlightening. Way to kick em when they're down, J. Thanks for the warm send off.

Jamie waves her off as she walks inside. Imani retreats to the back house. Once back inside she swipes her arm out and knocks the book to the floor. Throws the sculpture into the corner chair. She lies on the bed and stares at the ceiling, shaken.

BLACK

INT. BACK HOUSE MORNING

BLACK

The sound of a vacuum. Open on dimly lit dawn- eye level w/ Grif on the bed watching IMANI who enters the frame vacuuming. She ushers him off the bed. He jumps down and she vacuums the comforter as she straightens it.

CU on IMANIS phone- an email from PayPal stating she has received x dollars from ROBERT. And a text.

ROBERT

(text)

Hey, I lost your key. Had to climb
in window last night. Do you happen
to have a spare?

IMANI walks around the room making sure everything is
orderly. She opens the soap and sniffs it. She sees the email
and the text while putting the soap back.

IMANI

(under her breath)

Are you...this fuckin' guy...

IMANI (TEXT) (CONT'D)

Yes. B there shortly.

She tosses the phone in her bag. It bleeps. She picks up and
puts the missing/found book in with her belongings. She picks
up the sculpture and puts it back on the pedestal. She exits
the back house.

She gathers all the bottles from the patio and puts them into
a neat pile. Jaime's words affected her.

INT. CAR

Back in the car with Grif she eyes the rearview.

INT. BACK HOUSE

CU on sculpture, the door to the back house opens and Imani's
hand grabs the sculpture from the room and closes the door
behind her. We stay on the empty area where the sculpture
was and the door behind it.

EXT. IMANIS HOUSE

IMANI pulls up to the front of her house and gets out. The
scene we opened with.

IMANI stands at her mailbox...opens, pulls out the two
packages, closes, then descends the stairs to the car. This
time we see the package and the sticker that she puts on the
back window. It's a marine corps sticker. She gets in the
car. The package she tosses on top of the seat beside her is
an american flag screaming eagle car window shade. All in
american road trip a la her father's and Bill's advice. How
to be a woman in a car alone safely.

IMANI

OK.

Heading north on the freeway Imani drives silently. A 6am silence.

A pit stop. A 24 hour Target. Imani returns to the car with a camp stove. She sits silently contemplating her gear and the mission. She considers Grif and the gear again. She opens the map and eyes the BLM land north of San Francisco. Zooms in and explores it. Then she scrolls down... to San Jose...

She opens the text from Max. "Contact. ANDY SMALLS." She texts.

IMANI (TEXT) (CONT'D)

Hey Andy. Imani here. Wondering if it's good to stop through today and maybe say hello."

Tentatively fingers send, then commits. 30 seconds later the phone rings. It's 6 am. She's so startled she answers.

AND

HEYOOOOO! I'm up!

A large booming voice comes through the line. Imani pulls the phone away from her ear.

IMANI

Im, uh, sorry. Who is this?

ANDY

I mean you texted me.

IMANI

Andy?

ANDY

The one and only.

IMANI

Im sorry... did I wake you?

Shot of Andy in Scuba gear in his kitchen. On a land line.

ANDY

Nope. Up early for some diving. Just caught me on the way out the door.

IMANI

This is Imani, Max's friend?... the one coming thru the bay...Im actually on the road now and pretty far out still...

Imani hesitates. This was a stupid idea.

ANDY

Totally! Yeah, come over any time. Any friend o' Max is a friend o' mine. See you later, well, I'll probably already be asleep already, so let yourself in! I'll text the address!

IMANI

What? Really?

ANDY

Yeah, up at 3:30am tomorrow. Fit in a dive before the plumbers union meeting. Welp, gotta go!

IMANI

Wow great, ok. Thank you.

ANDY

Hey-o, all aboard!

Andy hangs up and walks off with flipper feet. Imani sits discombobulated. She tosses the phone onto the passenger seat. Clink.

Imani moves the blanket and there beneath the blanket, the sculpture she took from Michael's.

The signal light is ticking, she turns it off. She rests her hands on the steering wheel and a small tear forms in one of her eyes. Grif looks at her. She looks at him. Tension.

IMANI

Oh, you're fine!

Grif puts his head back down on the seat. She wipes at her almost tear. And obscures the statue with a bag of Funyuns.

From overhead rear we see Imani's car signal to pull out of the parking lot. She turns left and heads towards the freeway which reads...

SIGN

North, San Francisco 325 Miles

We watch as her car makes a right onto the freeway, cars file along and we watch hers disappear, one of many.

Run credits on the road.

*

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